

BETTER HALF: SHWETA AND SUDARSHAN MURTHY



"I started learning sign language to communicate with her better and faster."

HE IS: A techie based in Bangalore

SHE IS: From Kolkata; has a hearing disability

HIS PARENTS: Wanted a girl from the same caste

HER PARENTS: Were afraid that he won't be able to understand her problems

LOVE: Blossomed and he worked hard at convincing his parents. Shweta's hearing disability did not deter Sudarshan from his decision to marry her

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THE STORY: Shweta had lots of "ifs" and "buts" about a relationship with a "normal" man. After endless rounds of persuasion, he finally managed to convince both his and her parents.

grasped the need for "new kinds of complementarities" and not mechanical, quantifiable parameters in choosing life-partners. The changing demands are reflected in a study of over 3,000 matrimonial ads between 1967 and 1997 by the Centre for Social Research, Delhi. "There is a noticeable shift. From an exclusive focus on physical appeal to intellectual and economic merits of girls," points out Ranjana Kumari, director. "Similarly, boys are no longer judged solely by their financial worth, but more by personality traits and career prospects." And women, she holds, seem to be a lot more picky about the sort of partners they want. One palpable indicator of change is the rising age of marriage (in a 2007 ACNielsen survey, 79 per cent Indian men and women held 30s to be the right age for marriage).

Yet, experts hesitate to call it a "rebellion". Much of the new preferences of the youth, feels Tushar Guha, psychologist-counsellor with Nriyanjali in Mumbai, reflect a confused search for glamour and an attempt at social climbing. He comes across too many

While 76% men and women refused, 19% said "maybe" to disabled partners

young people who seem to seek "trophy wife and husband"—somebody who looks good, is well-educated and has a sparkling career graph. "But scratch below the surface, 60 per cent of the youth are still mama's boys or papa's girls," he holds. "They have just become smarter about choosing their partners." In a recent shaadi.com survey, 80 per cent young people said they would not marry without parental blessings. Mittal believes that there's probably more accommodation and adjustment working surreptitiously between parents and children. "Parents are now much more savvy. They understand what their children want. And together with the children, they are also putting a premium on compatibility, education, career, interests and hobbies," says Mittal.

Archit and Navina's union is a case in point. "I came across her profile,

initiated a contact and it was accepted the very next day," recalls Archit Manmohan, 36, of Kolkata. "It took us a month to speak to each other and then it was taken further by our parents." It didn't matter to either set of parents that Archit is a Marwari and Navina is from Punjab. Nobody bothered to check out horoscopes. Nor did anyone have any problems with the fact that Navina, 33, intended to carry on with her job at ABN-Amro Bank. "There was no difference with our parents' choice," underlines Manmohan, who works in an IT company. With parental blessings, they met last year and got engaged the same day. A month later, they got married.

The collision between modernity and tradition becomes apparent in the metro-specific figures thrown up by the shaadi.com survey. Along with the yearning for modernity there is an

88% Pune women wish to marry a metro man, **56%** in Kolkata do